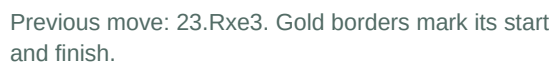


## Back-rank mates

## WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES



The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: rook on a1. Check for tactical protection.



**23...Qxf2+ 24. Kh1 Qf1+ 25. Rxf1 Rxf1#**

24...Qf1+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. From f1 it attacks king on h1 and rook on a1. Recorded reply:  
25.Rxf1.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on h1. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on f1. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

A flight square, an interposition, or a countercheck may refute an apparent mate. Check all three before sacrificing material.